

EDUCATION

EDUCATION IS ONE OF the most important ways of creating a better world, for it enables people to improve their own lives. Most children receive a primary education up to the age of 11, which gives them the basic skills of reading, writing, and mathematics. About half the world's children also receive a secondary education up to the age of 16 or 18, and some go on to higher education. But education provision varies greatly. Children in rich countries generally receive a better education than those in poorer areas. One of the biggest problems for poor countries is that their less-educated population is ill-prepared to cope with the demands of the modern world.



In the U.S., over a quarter of all young people go on to higher education.



These children are studying at a rural school in Haiti.

MALE AND FEMALE DIFFERENCES

In many countries, girls are not as well-educated as boys. Girls often leave school earlier and some are not educated at all. This might be for religious or economic reasons, because society thinks they should remain at home or because they are needed to work on the land. However, the situation is improving because educating women benefits the national economy.

In some countries girls are expected to leave school early to help in the home.

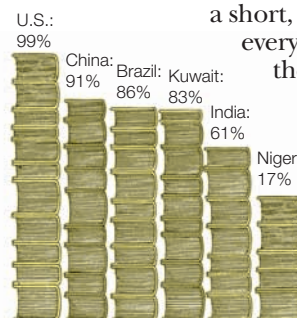


RURAL AND URBAN SCHOOLING

In the poorer countries of Africa and Asia, children who live in towns usually receive a better education than those who live in the countryside. This is because many country children are needed to stay at home to work the land and help in the family, and would have to travel long distances to get to school. However, educating rural children can bring great advantages, because they can develop skills to increase productivity in agriculture and local industry.

ADULT LITERACY

The adult literacy rate of a country shows how many adults over the age of 15 can read and write. The test involves asking a person to read and write a short, simple statement about their everyday life. In the U.S., for example, the literacy rate is 99 percent, which means that only one adult in 100 cannot read or write. In Niger in west Africa, however, the adult literacy rate is only 17 percent, which means that 83 people in every 100 cannot read or write.



Adult literacy rates

EDUCATION LEVELS

A country's ability to educate its people is related to its wealth. Rich countries can spend money on schools and teachers, as well as books and computers.

In turn, a good education adds to that country's wealth by producing qualified people to work in its offices, factories, and farms. Better education supplies more teachers, trains farmers to be more productive, and help office workers to be more efficient.

Children in Japan work hard to pass their exams. Many attend special classes on Saturdays or in the evenings.



EFFICIENT EDUCATION

Japan has one of the most efficient education systems in the world. Nearly all children attend a nursery school before they are old enough to go to primary school, and one-third of children stay on for higher education. Japanese children do well in science and math, which are subjects much in demand by industries.

Male and female differences in literacy rates

In each case the female figure is a percentage of the male average, which is given as 100. The closer the figure to 100, the smaller the gap in literacy rates.

